A Dispensational Panorama of the Bible

From Adam . . .

. . . to Moses
. . . to Christ
. . . to Paul

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A PANORAMA
OF THE BIBLE

The word "panorama" is a transliteration of the compound Greek word panorama, which means to see or view all. We are using it in this article to emphasize our need for an *overall view of the Bible.*

A fundamental principle in teachings that we must begin with what students *already know.* What we teach will not be meaningful and significant to students unless they are able to tie it in as a continuation of prerequisite knowledge.

We can no longer assume that those we are teaching today know anything about the Bible. Many of them have been held hostage so long under the diabolical theory of evolution, which has been taught as a fact in our humanistic government schools, that they are incapable of recognizing what is right and wrong. In fact, they have been in darkness so long that they would not know the light if they saw it.

Recently I asked a brilliant medical doctor, who has a Ph.D. in chemistry and an M.D. in medicine, why many medical doctors believe in evolution. His reply was: They have been taught this in schools, have accepted it as a fact, without investigating it.

The Synoptic Gospels (Matt., Mark and Luke) were written regarding the *Israelites,* and presume that the readers will know or be acquainted with the *basic essentials* from the Old Testament (cf. Matt. 5:21-43; Acts 7:1-53; 13:16-26; 17:2-3; 18:4-5). To introduce a person first to the New Testament, who has no background or knowledge of the Old Testament, is indeed beginning in the middle of a continuous story.

A scenario of the Bible must begin with Genesis, the first book of the Bible. As we open this book, the vain humanistic search for our roots ends; God is the answer!

The followngis a resume of what God created on the first six days. It is important that we distinguish between what God created (bara) *out of nothing* and that which He made out of what He had previously created.

Day one, God created (bara) the heavens and the earth (matter). He told the light to shine and He divided light from darkness (Gen. 1:1-5).

Second day, God made a firmament which divided the waters (Gen. 1:6-8).

Third day, God separated the waters from the dry land (earth), and He commanded the earth to bring forth vegetation (Gen. 1:9-13).

Fourth day, God made two great lights, the greater for the day and the lesser for the night. He also made the stars (Gen. 1:14-19).

Fifth day, God created (bara) all kinds of physical creatures living in water including winged birds (Gen. 1:20-23).

Sixth day, God made land animals, cattle and creeping things which live upon the earth. Also, on this day God created (bara) *man* (male and female) in His own image. Furthermore, God provided proper food for man and the other creatures (Gen. 1:24-31).

Summarizing, the Hebrew verb translated "Created" (bara) refers to that which is created out of nothing. The subject of "bara" in the Old Testament *is always God,* for He is the only one who is able to create something out of nothing.

Applying this fact to Genesis 1:1, God created out of nothing *the matter* used in the creation of the heavens and earth.

Applying this fact to Genesis 1:21 (20-25), God created the *physical life* in the water and upon land out of nothing.

Applying this fact to Genesis 1:27, *God created man* (male and female) in His own image, *a distinct creation,* out of nothing.

The Apostle Paul's consistent method and message, with respect to those who knew nothing about God, was to take them back to the first two chapters in Genesis.

Conclusion, A Panorama of the Bible must be based on *the literal account of creation* in the Book of Genesis and the *reaffirmation of the same* throughout the Bible (cf. Matt. 19:4; Jn. 1:3; Acts 4:24; Col. 1:16; et al).

To the extent that our generation is ignorant of God and His Word, like the heathen Gentiles were to whom Paul preached the Gospel of Grace, *we need to identify with his methodology.* Two examples reveal Paul's consistent message to those who were ignorant of God's Person and existence.

First, at Lystra in the Galatian region, Paul tells the idolworshiping Gentiles *"to turn to the living God, who made the heaven and the earth and the sea and all things in them"* (Acts 14:15). He also tells them that during the past God had allowed the Gentiles to go their own ways, had done good toward them, providing rain, fruit and food for their enjoyment (cf. Acts 14:16-17). Second, in Athens, Greece, Paul recounts to them that he had seen one of their altars, namely, TO AN UNKNOWN GOD. Taking off from this inscription, he said, "What therefore you worship in ignorance, this I proclaim to you. *The God who has made the world and all the things in it, He is Lord of heaven* and earth, does not dwell in handmade temples" (Acts 17:24). He also adds that this *God has given life and breath to all,* and that *out of one* (Adam) He made every nation of men dwelling upon the earth (Acts 17:25-26).

The Apostle Paul's consistent method and message, with respect to those who knew nothing about God, was to *take them back to the first two chapters in Genesis.* If we are going to prefix any other portion of Scripture to the New Testament, it should first be the *Book of Genesis.* It is *a prerequisite* for understanding it.

Again we emphasize, an accurate understanding of the Book of Genesis is a prerequisite for understanding how Adam and Eve and their progeny became engrossed in sin.

Next, observe that as the New Testament opens it depicts *all men as sinners* (cf. Matt. 1:21; Mark 1:4; Luke 1:77). The Jews, who know the Book of Genesis, knew how they had become sinners(Gen.3:1-8). This fact was also impressed upon the minds and conscience of each by the Law of Moses (cf. Rom. 3:19-20).

Also, as the Apostle Paul taught both Israelites and God-fearing *Gentiles* at Antinch of Pisidia, *he posits the fact that they are all sinners,* and as such, he offers to them justification through faith in Jesus Christ (cf. Acts 13:38-39).

After he had been persecuted out of Antioch, Paul went east to the city of Iconium. There he went into the synagogue as he had at Antioch and spoke in the "same manner" (ουτως) and *the same way* as he had at Antioch. This means that he *affirmed the fact that they were sinners* and needed justification (cf. Acts 14:1).

In dealing with those who were spiritually ignorant, engrossed in idolatry (cf. Acts 14:11-12, Paul tells them that GOD has created all things; He has created them. Following this *he designates* those who had been created by God, presumably perfect, *as sinners* in need of justification.

The thinking mind would be expected to ask: *How* did those whom God created perfect become sinners? *We must go back to the Book of Genesis for the answer* (cf. Gen. 3:1-8). Again we emphasize, an accurate understanding of the Book of Genesis is a *prerequisite* for understanding how Adam and Eve and their progeny became engrossed in sin (cf. Rom. 5:12,19).

Finally, as we approach the New Testament, particularly, the Synoptic Gospels and the *forepart of the Book of Acts,* we must recognize that *these are a continuation of Old Testament prophecy.* The main burden of Old Testament prophecy is that *a descendant of King David will establish and reign over a great Kingdom upon this earth* (Isa. 11:1-5, 9-12; 33:17-24; Jer. 23:58; 33:14-17).

As the New Testament opens with the Book of Matthew, John the Baptist comes on the scene declaring, "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand: (Matt. 3:2. The Greek verb translated "at hand" (ηγγικεν) means that this prophesied kingdom *has drawn near and its establishment is impending.*

We observe that when Jesus began His ministry, He preached and said, "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand" (Matt. 4:17). This statement is *the same as that uttered by John the Baptist* in the third chapter (cf. Matt. 10:7).

Furthermore, *accompanying the kingdom* which was prophesied in the Old Testament *were physical healings.* After Jesus had healed people of many diseases

(Matt. 8:16-17), the Holy Spirit says that this is a fulfillment of what Isaiah prophesied: "He Himself took our infirmities and He bore the diseases" (cf. Isa.53:4a). When we open the NewTestament in the light of the foregoing Old Testament prophecies to the Jews - it makes sense!

Since the kingdom prophesied in the Old Testament is to be established on this earth, constituted of *physical people,* it is logical that the healing of bodies was a part of *its presentation to Israel in the Synoptic Gospels, a part of its offer to Israel in the forepart of Acts,* and *apart of confirming that Jesus is the Christ,* the King, in Acts 8:1-28:10.

The central subject of the Old Testament revolves around *Israel.* The Holy Spirit consummated their history, as far as the Old Testament is concerned,with the Book of Malachi. Following this there is an intermission which ends with the record in the Synoptic Gospels. The flow of Old Testament prophecy, *as it relates to Israel as an earthly people, continues through the Synoptic Gospels and the first seven chapters in Acts.* We need to know the Old Testament that we might know what *pertains to Israel* in the New Testament.

DISTINGUISHING WHAT IS DIFFERENT IN THE BIBLE

Our title is taken from Philippians 1:10, the following being an accurate translation from the Greek: "unto the end that you prove the things differing, that you may be sincere and without offense unto the day of Christ." The Greek word translated "prove" (dokimazein) commonly means *to test, examine* and *distinguish.* If we are going to be sincere and without offense in handling the Bible, the Word of God, we must put what it says to the *test, prove* and *examine* it and *distinguish* between those things which are different (cf. 2 Tim. 2:15).

THE BIBLE IS INERRANT

When we use the phrase, the Word of God, in its broader sense it includes all that is written in the Bible. God the Holy Spirit, via human instruments, has placed *what He wanted* in the Bible; i.e., He has written and *determined* what is included in it. In the Bible God has given to us a concise, infallible and inerrant record of *His dealings with men,* and *their response,* from the creation of Adam and Eve through the Book of Revelation. Prophetically speaking, it even mentions the time when Christ gives the kingdom to God the Father (cf. 1 Cor. 15:24).

Again we emphasize, everythingwhich is in the Bible is in it *in accordance with God's will.* This does not mean, however, that everything recorded in the Bible is a direct expression of God's will for men. On the one hand, God has progressively *revealed His will* for men in given situations during different periods of time (cf. Eph. 3:10-11). On the other hand, God has recorded *the response of men* to His will during these different periods of time. In every situation in every period, men have confirmed that they are disobedient, rebellious sinners without excuse (cf. Rom. 1:20; 3:9-18).

THE CREATION ACCOUNT WAS WRITTEN FOR ALL MEN

As we positively affirm that the Bible is the inspired, infallible and incrrant Word of God in the original manuscripts, the Hebrew and Greek, we must likewise affirm that God created eve rything *in six calendar days.* If we begin adjusting our Biblical hermeneutics to align with humanistic evolution, *which is on trial* by many of the best minds today, where will we stop interpreting the Bible in the light of man's foolishness (cf. 1 Cor.1:20-24). The account of creation, as we have it in Genesis and affirmed throughout the Bible, is *the premise upon which all God's dealings with men rests* (cf. Rom. 5:12-14). Those who tamper with the literal meaning of Genesis *create impossible theological problems* for themselves!

OBSERVE TO WHOM IT WAS SPOKEN

God's first recorded words *to Adam and Eve* were, "of every tree of the garden you may freely eat, but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, you shall not eat of it, for in the day that you eat thereof you shall surely die" (Gen. 2:16-17). This

is a part of the Bible, it was specifically spoken to Adam and Eve, but it is *not to be obeyed by us* in this Church age.

After a space of many hundreds of years, "Jehovah saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every imagination of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually (Gen. 6:5). There was an exception, however, for "Noah found favor in the eyes of Jehovah ... he was a righteous man ... and he walked with God" (Gen. 6:8-9). In view of the violence of men on the earth at that time (cf. Gen. 6:13), *God's words to Noah were,* "You make an ark of gopher wood ... the length of the ark three hundred cubits, the breadth of it fifty cubits, and the height of it thirty cubits" (Gen. 6:14-15). These words, including the instructions which follow them, are a part of what God specifically spoke to Noah, but are certainly not *to be obeyed by us* in this present dispensation of grace (cf. Eph. 3:2).

As we positivefy affirm that the Bible is the inspired, infallible and inerrant Word of God in the original manuscripts, the Hebrew and Greek, we must likewise affirm that God created everything in six calendar days.

Over eighteen hundred years B.C. *God said to Abram (Abraham),* "Get out of your country, and from your kindred, and from your father's house, unto the land that I will show you, and I will make of you a great nation, and I will bless you, and make your name great" (Gen. 12:1-2). At a later date we are told,"In that day Jehovah made a covenant with Abram, saying, "Unto your seed I have given this land, from the river of Egypt unto the great river, the river Euphrates" (Gen.15:18). All the covenants which God made with Abraham and promises have not yet been fulfilled; however, we can rest assured, *they will be in God's due time!* All these things which God said to Abraham are a part of the Bible. They involved certain things which he was to do and receive. *No one has the fight to claim or latch on to the territory* which God has given to Israel via a covenant made with Abraham!

THE LAW OF MOSES WAS GIVEN TO ISRAEL

In the third month after the children of Israel had left Egypt, they came to Mount Sinai. There Moses went up unto God, "and Jehovah called unto him out of the Mountain, saying, ‘Thus you shall say to the house of Jacob, and tell the children of Israel: You have seen what I did unto the Egyptians, and how I bore you on eagles’ wings, and brought you unto myself. Now therefore, if you will obey my voice indeed, and keep my covenant, then you shall be mine own possession from among all the peoples; for all the earth is mine, and you shall be unto me a kingdom of priests, and a holy nation··· (Exod. 19:3-6).

When Moses called together the elders of the children of Israel, and presentcd to them the foregoing introduction to the Law, "all the people answered together, and said, `All that Jehovah has commanded we will do"' (Exod. 19:8). Following Israel's readiness to be under the Law, God spoke the Ten Commandments to them through Moses (cf. Exod. 20:3-17). The Ten Commandments, the Decalogue, is the heart of

the Law of Moses and is part of the Bible which was *specifically spoken to the children of Israel.*

The Ten commandments, the Decalogue, is the heart of the law of Moses and is part of the Bible which was specifically spoken to the children of Israel.

The real underlying purpose of the Law was to impress the exceeding sinfulness of sin upon the conscience of the Israelites. The Law, having fulfilled this purpose for some 1400years, was *replaced by the Antitype,* the crucified, resurrected and living Christ (cf. Rom. 7:13; 10:4; Gal. 3:21-22). The Law of Moses is in the Bible, but it is *not even God's Word for Israelites today,* let alone the Gentiles who were never under it, unless they were proselytes. Paul says in Romans 6:14, "you are not under law but under grace."

JESUS' EARTHLY MINISTRY TO ISRAEL

In the Synoptic Gospels (Matthew, Mark and Luke) Jesus proclaimed that the *kingdom of the heavens is near* (Matt. 4:17). The similarity between conditions in this kingdom and the conditions involved in the New Covenant strongly suggest that the kingdom referred to in the Synoptic Gospels *will be contemporaneous* with the prophesied New Covenant (Jer. 31:31). It will be a time when God will sovereignly put His laws into the inward parts and in the hearts of His people, Israel (Jer. 31:33). God will require *a much higher lifestyle in the New Covenant kingdom* than required by the Law of Moses (cf. Matt. 5:17-48). The fact that the New Covenant is based on *the Blood of Christ* makes this possible (Heb. 9:15). The significant *role of the Holy Spirit* in the New Covenant makes it possible (2 Cor. 3:6). The fact that *Satan will be bound* during Christ's kingdom reign makes it possible (Rev. 20:1-3).

THE CROSS PRECEDES THE OFFER OF THE KINGDOM

During the Synoptic Gospel period, Jesus *presented only the truth regarding the kingdom.* Since the forgiveness of Israel's sin was a prerequisite to the establishment of the kingdom and the New Covenant, His death on the Cross *had to come first* (cf. Jer. 31:34; Matt. 26:28; Heb. 9:12). We must never forget that "without the shedding of blood there is no remission" of sins (Heb. 9:22). As the Mediator of the New Covenant, Jesus Christ died potentially for every sin which has been committed in the world - past, present and future (Heb. 9:15).

Furthermore, we must recognize that *there is no overlapping between* the Old and New covenants. By this we mean that the earthly sanctuary, which was a copy and pattern of the heavenly sanctuary, *had fulfilled its purpose when Christ entered into the heavenly sanctuary, i.e.,* into heaven itself with His own Blood (cf. Heb. 7:12; 9:8; 10:9; 9:12, 24). God's plan *never* has encompassed Israel under the Old Covenant and the Body of Christ under the Blood of Christ *simultaneously.* There is *no further need of the type* when the antitype, what it represented, was present.

Considering God's message in the Synoptic Gospels, that it is *parallel to the New Covenant,* and that it includes the first third of the Book of Acts, it is obvious that *this kingdom will operate on the basis of law.* All the truth pertaining to this kingdom has *been given to Israel;* its establishment is *still in the future.* The truth regarding it is a part of the Bible, but it is *not for us to obey* who live under grace.

NOT WRITTEN TO US,

BUT FOR ENCOURAGING HOPE

Now let us scan the foregoing portion of the Bible *which has not been directly addressed to* us members of the Body of Christ, the Church. First, there is that which was spoken *to Adam and Eve* (Gen. 2:16-17). Second, we have a record of that which was *spoken to Noah* (Gen. 6:14-7:4). Third, there is an account of *God's covenant with Abraham* and promise spoken to him (Gen. 12:1-3; et al). Fourth, we have the story of how God began and continued to speak *the Law to Moses* until completed (Exod. 19:3-20:17; et al). Fifth, we have the record of *Jesus' ministry in the Synoptic Gospels* and the Spirit's ministry in the first third of the Book of Acts (Acts 1-8).

His death enabled God the Father to forgive and obliterate all sin, particularly, that which had been covered by prior sacrifices and the Old Covenant (Heb. 9:15).

Having positively affirmed that the foregoing portions of the Bible *have not been spoken or written TO believers under grace,* we acknowledge that God has put them in His inspired, infallible and inerrant Word *FOR the encouragement of our hope.* The Apostle Paul says in Romans 15:4, "For as much as was previously written, it was written for our teaching, in order that through the patience and through the comfort of the Scriptures we might have hope."

The Greek phrase translated "For as much as was previously written" (οσα γαρ προεγραφη) refers to all that had been written prior to the Apostle Paul. In explaining the reason *why these things were written in the Bible,* Paul says, it was "for our teaching" (εις ημετερου διδασκαλιαν) or unto the end of our *instruction and information.* These things had a primary purpose in the past, but the main focus here is on God's secondary purpose. He has included them in the Bible that through the "patience" (υπομονης) and *endurance* and the "comfort" (παρακαλησεως) and *encouragement* of the Scriptures we *might have hope.* The thought is that reading the Scriptures which were written prior to Paul's time would *incite one to greater endurance* and *encouragement* resulting in *a strengthened hope.*

THE FIRST DIVIDING LINE - THE CROSS

The main dividing line between the Old Covenant and the New Covenant *is the Cross.* The Law of Moses was God's method of *covering sin until the Cross.* It was in effect during Jesus Christ's earthly ministry, and He says that He did not come to

destroy it but to fulfill it, *which He did on the Cross* (Rom. 10:3-4). His death enabled God the Father to forgive and obliterate all sin, particularly, that which had been covered by prior sacrifices and the Old Covenant (Heb. 9:15). The Cross is indeed the *dividing line* between the *sacrificial system of the Old Covenant* and the *Supreme Sacrifice of the New Covenant,* applicable to both the Kingdom and Church.

On the basis of Jesus Christ's death on the Cross, through which He obtained eternal redemption for all past, present and future sins, the Holy Spirit OFFERED the prophesied kingdom to Israel (cf. Jer. 31:34; Acts 2:30, 31; et al). As Christ and His kingdom continued to be offered to Israel, opposition to it increased (cf. Acts 4:3, 29; 5:17-18, 33, 40; 6:9-12).

Stephen, after he had presented a pertinent summary of Israel's history to the council, indicted them, saying, "You stiff-necked and uncircumcised in heart and ears, you always resist the Holy Spirit; as your fathers also you" (Acts 7:51). We must keep in mind that when Israel's leaders refused to respond to what Stephen said, they were not merely forcefully resisting and opposing a wise man, but they were resisting the Holy Spirit Himself (cf. Acts 6:5, 10). Stephen likens their antipathy toward Jesus Christ to the murderous attitude of their fathers toward the prophets who announced His coming (Acts 7:52).

As the religious leaders heard the things which Stephen was saying, and could not deny them, they were furious in their hearts and gnashed their teeth at him (Acts 7:54). Next, the crowd having shouted with a great voice, having stopped their cars, rushed upon him, and having cast him out of the city, he was asking the Lord to forgive them while they were stoning him to death (Acts 7:58-60).

We may look at the offer of the Messianic Kingdom as a scenario which begins with the coming of the Holy Spirit on the Day of Pentecost and ends with the death of Stephen. The offer of the Kingdom appears to teach its climax as the Holy Spirit identifies Jesus Christ as THE PROPHET predicted by Moses (cf. Deut.18:15; Acts 3:22; 7:37). The rejection of the Kingdom was sealed by the death of Stephen. However, when ready, God will sovereignly establish this Kingdom under Jesus Christ (cf. Matt. 24:36).

THE SECOND DIVIDING LINE –

THE REJECTED KINGDOM

Under this heading we want to take a brief look at the period of time between the Cross and the rejection of the prophesied Messianic Kingdom. Failure to distinguish between what the Word of God says was happening during this time and what religious tradition says has caused much confusion.

The first thing the Disciples did after the Cross and Resurrection was to replace Judas with Matthias, that they might have Twelve Disciples to represent the Twelve Tribes of Israel. The second thing was that after having ascended, Jesus Christ received from God the Father His promise of the Spirit, Who came on the Day of Pentecost in accordance with Joel's Kingdom prophecy (cf. Joel 2:28-29; Jer. 31:31-34; Luke 24:49; Acts 2:16-18). Both the selection of Matthias and the coming of the Spirit relate to the prophesied Kingdom, not the Body of Christ!

We may look at the offer of the Messianic Kingdom as a scenario which begins with the coming of the Holy Spirit on the Day of Pentecost and ends with the death of Stephen.

The third thing the Disciples did was to declare that the crucifixion of Jesus Christ was according to the determinate counsel and foreknowledge of God. The Greek participle translated "determine" (ωρισμενη) is in the perfect tense and passive voice, which means that God is the One Who had willed, purposed and designed the death of Jesus Christ for sinners (Acts 2:23). This was effected through "lawless" (ανομων) men, i.e., men who did not have the Law, Gentiles (v. 23b; cf. 4:27-28).

The fourth thing the Disciples proclaimed was the resurrection of Jesus Christ. According to what David said as a prophet, he obviously foresaw the resurrection of Jesus Christ as a prerequisite to His reigning as King over the Messianic Kingdom (Acts 2:24, 30-31; cf. 4:2).

The fifth thing the Disciples very positively affirmed was that God had made Jesus of Nazareth both LORD and CHRIST (Messiah; Acts 2:36).

The sixth thing the Disciples required the Israelites to do in preparation for the establishment of the Kingdom was for each one of them to repent and be baptized in or on the basis of the name of Jesus Christ. As a result of meeting these two conditions their sins would be forgiven and they would receive the gift of the Holy Spirit (Acts 2:38; cf. 3:19).

The seventh thing the Disciples were doing was they were persisting in the teaching of the Apostles. The Greek phrase translated "the teaching" (τη διδαχη) of the Apostles is preferable rather than the Apostles' doctrine. Beyond what is said in the first chapters in the Book of Acts, we would expect many similarities between the teaching of the Apostles and what is written in the Synoptic Gospels. The teaching of the Apostles was obviously Kingdom truth which was pertinent in the offering of the Kingdom to Israel (Acts 2:42).

The eighth thing in which the Disciples were involved between the Cross and the rejection of the Kingdom was the communal sharing of possessions. They had all things in common and distributed according to need (Acts 2:44-45; cf. 4:32-37).

The ninth thing the Disciples did was heal a lame man who was over 40 years old. This was a miracle which could not be denied, all Jerusalem knew about it, and it triggered aggressive persecution by the religious leaders against the Disciples (cf. Acts 3:6-8; 4:17-18, 21-22; 5:17-18, 27-28, 33, 40).

The tenth thing, as a result of the religious leaders' opposition, the Disciples had an opportunity to proclaim Jesus Christ, the Messiah, to the leaders of Israel. Peter informs them that if they repent God will send Christ Jesus from heaven to restore all

things referred to by Moses and the prophets (Acts 3:18-26). As Peter, John and the other Disciples stand before the religious leaders, theygive the living, resurrected Christ full credit for healing the lame man (Acts 4:8-10).

Continuing this tenth point, the Disciples emphasized that salvation cannot be found in anyother person or name; i.e., Jesus Christ is the Messiah, there are no others (Acts 4:12). The Disciples declare that they are following God's orders, and they are unable to speak other than what they have seen and heard (Acts 4:19-20; cf. Acts 5:29).

This strong, uncompromising offer of the King and His Kingdom left Israel without excuse, but not without forgiveness, for God will fulfill His His ur□conditional promises made to Abraham and his descendants!

Continuing to speak to the religious leaders, the Disciples affirm that God exalted Jesus Christ to His right hand as a Prince and Saviour to give repentance and forgiveness of sins to Israel (Acts 5:31; cf. 3:15; 2:33). Observe, during this time the repentance and forgiveness of sins was limited to Israel (cf. Acts 11:19). During the last recorded assault of the religious leaders against the Disciples, Gamaliel rescued them from death, but not without a beating and warning to refrain from proclaiming Jesus Christ (Acts 5:40).

Having considered the assault of the religious leaders against the Twelve Disciples, as they OFFERED THE KINGDOM to Israel, and how the Disciples did not recriminate, but rejoiced because they were counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the Name, we observe that *nothing deterred them from carrying out God's orders* (Acts 5:41). In spite of the times they had been beaten and warned not to mention Jesus Christ, they never ceased teaching and proclaiming the good news that Jesus is the Christ, the Messiah, in both the houses and the temple (Acts 5:42).

The Holy Spirit certainly concludes the offer of the King and His Kingdom, *by the Disciples,* on a victorious note! They indeed had proved themselves to be adequate channels through whom the Spirit of God could appeal to Israel's religious leaders to acccpt Jesus of Nazareth, the Messiah, as their prophesied King. This strong, uncompromising offer of the King and His Kingdnтn *left Israel without excuse, but not without forgiveness, for God will fulfill His unconditional promises made to Abraham and his descendants!*

In the process of time, as those who believed that Jesus was the Messiah waited for Him to establish His Kingdom, some of them began to *complain about inequities in the distribution of food* under the communal system. The result was that seven qualified men were put in charge of this part of the ministry. The most notable of these was Stephen, a man full of faith and of the Holy Spirit (Acts 6:5).

STEPHEN'S CLIMACTIC OFFER
OF THE KINGDOM TO ISRAEL

According to the record in the Book of Acts (6:8-7:60), Stephen was a man full of grace and power, which was manifested in his *performing of great miracles* and *irrefutable preaching of Jesus of Nazareth, that He is indeed the Messiah,* the King of Israel.

When those who opposed Stephen were not able to resist the wisdom and Spirit by whom he spoke, they seized him and brought him before the Sanhedrin, the highest ecclesiastical council in Israel. They induced or bribed false witnesses to say that he continually spoke against the temple, the Law and the customs of Moses. When the high priest asks Stephen if these things are so, the following is a synopsis of his answer.

Stephen does not waste his time answering these false charges, rather he gives a brief survey of Israel's history, closing with an indictment against the religious leaders of Israel at the time.

First, this survey begins with *God appearing to Abraham.* He promises to give to him and his descendants *the land of Canaan* after an interval of 400 years in Egypt (7:2-8).

Second, Stephen states that *God was with Joseph* in Egypt, his prestigious position, and the reason Jacob and his descendants moved there (7:9-15).

Third, Stephen *explains conditions in Egypt* as the fulfillment of God's promise to Abraham approaches, and how God preserved and trained Moses (7:17-22).

Fourth, Moses' *first try* to alleviate the unjustice being done to his brethren, the Israelites, was rejected by them (7:23-29).

Fifth, 40 years later GOD sends Moses as *His deliverer* to Egypt (7:30-34).

Sixth, the one they had refused, *God made a ruler and deliverer* to lead them out of Egypt, and Moses said to them, "God will raise up for you a prophet out of your brethren like me" (7:35-38).

Seventh, Stephen says that *they did not obey the living oracles God gave to Moses,* but sacrificed to a calf they made, and their idolatry resulted in the Babylonian captivity (7:39-45).

Eighth, since they had accused Stephen of speaking against the temple, he says that Solomon built the temple, but that *the Most High does not dwell in handmade temples* (7:46-50).

Ninth, having presented the foregoing historical evidence to the religious leaders of Israel, Stephen states the following *indictment against them: they always resist the Holy Spirit* as their fathers did. Their fathers persecuted the prophets who predicted the coming of the Messiah, and *they have killed Him.* They had received the Law of Moses, but *they had not kept it* (7:51-53).

Tenth, the final stage, Israel's religious leaders *climax their rejection of the Messianic Kingdom,* the Kingdom of Christ, with the stoning of Stephen to death.

A TRANSITIONAL PERIOD

After the rejection of Jesus of Nazareth as the Messiah, and the refusal of Israel's Council to acknowledge Him as the *King over the prophesied Messianic Kingdom,* the following chapters in the Book of Acts continue to CONFIRM THAT HE IS THE MESSIAH (8-12). These chapters serve as a bridge over which we are mentally transported *from Kingdom Truth to Church truth;* therefore, we have designated them as *a transitional period.*

PHILIP is the first one the Holy Spirit uses to confirm the fact that Jesus is the Messiah, the Christ (cf. Acts 8:5,12, 35, 37).

SAUL of Tarsus, following his miraculous conversion, was the second one the Holy Spirit used to confirm that Jesus is the Messiah. We are first introduced to him as one who was consenting to the death of Stephen (Acts 7:58; 8:1). Also, he was endeavoring to destroy and imprison those who believed that Jesus is the Messiah (Acts 8:3; 1 Tim. 1:13).

According to Acts 9:5,15-16, *the name "Lord" is inclusive of Messiah,* a name which Saul was to bear before the Gentiles, kings and the Israelites. According to Acts 9:20, Saul proclaimed that Jesus is the *Son of God, a name inseparable from the Messiah* (cf. Jn. 20:31). According to Acts 9:22, Paul was proving to the Jews in Damascus that *Jesus is the Messiah, the Christ* (cf. Acts 9:27-28).

PETER was the third one the Holy Spirit used to confirm that Jesus is the Messiah. He speaks of the proclamation of peace through Jesus Christ, the anointed One, the Messiah (Acts 10:36).

After the rejection of Jesus of Nazareth as the Messiah, and the refusal of Israel's Council to acknowledge Him as the King over the prophesied Messianic Kingdom, the following chapters in the Book of Acts continue to CONFIRM THAT HE IS THE MESSIAH (8:12).

According to Acts 10:42, Peter had been commanded to bear witness to Jesus Christ, the One ordained by God as a judge of the living and dead. Peter baptized in the name of Jesus Christ, i.e., in the name of Jesus who is the Messiah (Acts 10:48).

CYPRIANS and CYRENEANS, apparently Jews or proselytes, were the fourth ones used by the Holy Spirit to evangelize and confirm that Jesus is Lord, i.e., the Messiah (11:20).

JAMES, the brother of John, was the fifth one used by the Holy Spirit to confirm that Jesus is the Messiah. The fact that his death pleased the Jews strongly suggests that he was *aggressively confirming that Jesus is the Messiah* (Acts 12:2-3).

We positively affirm that PETER was destined for the same fate, from which he was miraculously delivered, because he also *boldly corifirmed that the Jesus is the Messiah.*

THE EMERGENCE OF SAUL OF TARSUS

Having observed that during this transitional period, chapters 8-12 of Acts, the continuing thrust of the disciples was that Jesus is the Messiah, we now turn our attention to the emergence of Saul of Tarsus on the scene. He was *miraculously saved* during the post-rejection period in accordance with continuing Kingdom principles, namely, repentance and baptism (Acts 2:38; 22:16).

Even though Saul of Tarsus was saved when hangover Kingdom principles were fading away, he never became involved in the furtherance of these principles. According to the record available to us *his main emphasis in these early years focused on the fact that Jesus of Nazareth is the Messiah* (Acts 9:22; cf. 17:2-3, 11).

Furthermore, during this transitional period the Holy Spirit was apparently revealing to him *special insight into the significance of the Old Testament regarding the issue of salvation,* i.e., since the Law was no longer in effect, *how God was now going to bring sinners into a righteous relationship with Himself* (cf. Acts 9:29; Gal. 1:17-18). It is reasonable to think that when Barnabas brought Saul down to Antioch, that the latter became a key teacher there, *and began to infuse in the minds of others truths which* the Holy Spirit was revealing to him (cf. Acts 11:25-26).

As we move toward the end of the transitional period following the rejection of the Messianic Kingdom, we observe at Antioch a very definite *transition away from kingdom principles.* For example: 1. Peter with Saul, via Spirit-revealed insight, recognized that *forgiveness of sin was by faith in Jesus Christ* (Acts 10:43). 2. Some *Gentiles were given the opportunity to believe on Jesus Christ* (Acts 10:34-36; 11:20). 3. There is *no emphasis on water baptism* at Antioch nor later in Galatia. 4. They were *guided and directed by the Holy Spirit,* not by Jerusalem (Acts 13:2, 4). 5. Finally, when both Jews and Gentiles believed on Jesus Christ, they were *first called Christians at Antioch,* i.e., believers in and followers of Christ (Acts 11:26; cf. 1 Cor. 10:32).

SUMMARY OF THE SYNOPTIC GOSPELS AND THE FIRST SEVEN CHAPTERS IN ACTS

In the Synoptic Gospels, Jesus Christ *presents* the truth pertaining to His earthly kingdom, which according to Old Testament prophecy will be established upon this earth (Isa. 9:6-7; Matt. 4:17; 25:31-34). This kingdom *will operate on the basis of the Law of the New Covenant,* the requirements of which are more stringent than the Mosaic Law (cf. Matt. 5:21-48; Jer. 31:31-34).

In the first seven chapters in the Book of Acts, the Kingdom which was presented in Matthew, Mark and Luke was *offered to Israel by the Holy Spirit through the disciples.* A clear example of the offer of the kingdom to Israel is made by the Holy Spirit through Peter in Acts 3:17-26. The thought is that if Israel would have repented, God the Father *would have sent Jesus Christ from heaven to establish the prophesied Kingdom.*

Instead of repenting, the leaders of Israel persistently rejected the Holy Spirit's offer of the Messiah, the King and His Kingdom, which rejection was consummated by their stoning of Stephen to death (Acts 7:59-60). In view of Israel's rejection of the offer of this kingdom, does this mean that God's promise to Abraham, Isaac, Jacob and Moses, and confirmed by the prophets is now void? The answer would be yes *if God's promise to Abraham and his descendants was conditional, i.e.,* contingent on their response.

Even as God sovereignly called Abraham out of a heathen background with an *unconditional call, He promised to make his descendants a great nation,* to give them a land extending from the river of Egypt (the Nile) to the Euphrates River, and to bless all the families of the earth through them with an unconditional promise (Gen. 12:1-3; 15:18; 17:7-8, 19; 28:13-14; 35:9-12).

IN HIS DUE TIME GOD WILL ESTABLISH THE KINGDOM

The fact that the prophesied Kingdom will be established on this earth is *clearly stated in the Bible* (Isa. 9:6-7; 24:23; Jer. 10:10; 31:31-34; Psa.145:10-14; Acts 1:6; 3:19-25; Rev. 20:4-6). It appears to me that the reason God *first offered* this Kingdom to Israel on a conditional basis, repentance and water baptism, *was to prove to them the fact that they are totally depraved sinners, and as such, without excuse* (cf. Rom. 1:20).

Having confronted Israel, as a part of the human race, with their sinful depravity, as sort of a final addendum to the Law, God reinforced the fact that *neither they nor any man can save himself, and is without excuse.* The manifestation of this depravity should have caused many to recognize their need of God's Grace provided for them in Jesus Christ.

Now that we have considered the rejection of the kingdom, and *its potential to stimulate a consciousness of sin,* we acknowledge that God's eternal purpose to bless all the families of the earth in conjunction with Christ's earthly Kingdom *was temporarily cut off.* The Mosaic Law was God's method for governing His people only up to the Cross, not beyond (Gal. 3:23-25).

While under the Old Covenant, the Mosaic Law; the Israelites looked forward to the time when it would be *replaced by a new covenant involving the death and reign of the Son of David, the Son of God,* over an earthly kingdom (cf. Jer. 31:31-34; Isa. 9:6-7). The Cross was the *basis* on which this new covenant was to be established, *making it possible for God to forgive their iniquity and sin* (Jer. 31:34).

The Mosaic Law was God's method for governing His people only unto the cross, not beyond (Gal. 3:23-25).

If Jesus Christ, His sacrificial death, and His Kingdom had been accepted by the Israelites, then *Gods prophetic program would have continued as set forth in the Old*

Testament. However, due to Israel's rejection of her Messiah-King and His Kingdom, God's prophetic program *has been temporarily put on hold* (Rom. 11:26), held in abeyance, until the time when *God sovereignly establishes His Son as King over Israel,* and extends the Kingdom blessings to all His people (Gen. 12:1-3).

Now we raise a very important question: *What about the interval between Israel's rejection of Christ and His Kingdom and God's sovereign establishment of this Kingdom in His due time.* This interval is now approaching 2000 years, that is, since the Old Covenant was terminated in favor of the New Covenant and Kingdom, which was rejected by Israel's leaders. With this temporary cutoff of God's purpose set forth in Old Testament prophecy,what has been God's response? Does it mean that He has been defeated by the sinfulness of those whom He has created?

In Psalm 76:10, the Spirit of God says through David, "Surely the wrath of man shall praise You." Also in Romans 9:17, in explaining the basic reason for Pharaoh's wrath, the Apostle Paul quotes Exodus 9:16: "For this reason I raised you up that I might show in you my power, and that my name may be declared in all the earth." I see the wrath of man that caused Israel to reject Jesus Christ and His Kingdom as *effecting a minimum of two things:* 1. *increasing their consciousness of their sinfulness;* and 2*, opening the door for God to reveal the exceeding riches of HIS GRACE,* the MYSTERY TRUTH regarding the BODY OF CHRIST, THE CHURCH.

As we move toward the crux of *what was to take the place of the rejected kingdom,* let us reflect on *the changes* which were taking place at Antioch during this *transitional period* which followed the rejection (cf. Acts 8:1-12:25). First, *they continued to confirm* that Jesus of Nazareth is the Messiah. Second, during this time *the emphasis was on believing* rather than on repenting. Third, we note that there was *a waning emphasis on water baptism.* Fourth, the disciples there were *the first ones to be called Christians.* Fifth, as we approach the end of this period *the trappings of the Law were sloughing off* - making room for something new.

In contrast, it appears that most of the Jews in Jerusalem and its environs who believed that Jesus is the Messiah were also, to a greater or lesser extent, *entangled in the Mosaic Law* (cf. Acts 21:20-21; Gal. 4:24-25; Heb. 13:13). Why the big difference between the disciples in these two cities? We trace the answer back to ONE MAN, Saul of Tarsus, who was soon to be given a new name, THE APOSTLE PAUL.

THE HOLY SPIRIT SEPARATES BARNABAS AND SAUL

In Acts 13:2, the Holy Spirit said, "Separate to Me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them." The Greek verb translated "separate" (aforisate), as used in this context, means that they were to be *set apart* unto the work to which the Holy Spirit had called them. The emphasis in this verse is not so much on being *separated from* the other teachers at Antioch, but on being *separated unto a new work* by the Holy Spirit.

Why was Saul separated? First, because the Lord had already begun to give him special insight into the *salvation aspect* of a new gospel unto him (Acts 20:24; Gal. 1:11-12; cf. Eph. 1:13). Second, because God was going to continue to reveal to

him the *mystery aspect* of the Gospel, i.e., "the mystery of the gospel" (Eph. 6:19; 3:2-9; 1 Cor. 2:6-10). Both of these aspects of the gospel constitute THE GOSPEL OF THE GRACE OF GOD (Acts 20:24).

We must keep in mind that nothing is said about the Church, the Body of Christ, in the Old Testament.

Why was Barnabas separated with Saul? First, because of his *close association with Saul* he knew that salvation is by Grace through faith. Second, because he was the *best qualified* fellow worker the Holy Spirit had at that time (Acts 11:24).

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF TWO IMPORTANT CHANGES

First, the name of Saul of Tarsus is *changed to* PAUL, as one full of the Holy Spirit he stood against Elymas, a son of the devil (Acts 13:6-11). The fact that the Lord gave him a new name emphasizes that he was indeed *separated by the Holy Spirit unto a new work,* a new gospel, apart from the works of the Law (Acts 13:38; Rom. 3:20).

Second, after the change of Saul's name to Paul, the next time his relative position in the missionary party is mentioned, *he is the leader.* From this time on it is "Paul and his party" (οι περι Παυλον), *those around him* or *his company* (Acts 13:13). This indicates that the Apostle Paul was not only *the One to whom the new Gospel of the Grace of God had and was being revealed,* but he was *also the leader in promulgating and making it known* (1 Cor. 9:16-22).

The fact that Saul's original Hebrew name was replaced by the new name Paul, and the fact that Barnabas, who could be influenced by Judaic legalism, was replaced by Paul as leader indicate that the Holy Spirit wanted the new Grace Gospel *separated from the laws of* both the old and new covenants (cf. Gal. 2:13; Rom. 6:14-15).

THE SPECIFIC TRUTH

WRITTEN TO THE BODY OF CHRIST

We must keep in mind *that nothing is said about the Church,* the Body of Christ, in the Old Testament. It is not a part of the truth which was prophesied in the Old Testament. The Greek phrase "γραφων προφητικον" in Romans 16:26, which is correctly translated "prophetic writings," *refers to what the Apostle Paul and those associated with him wrote* (cf. Rom. 16:25; 1 Cor. 2:6-8; Eph. 3:4-5). For further information on this verse see our commentary on Romans, Volume 2.

The Apostle Paul refers to the *New Truth* which God revealed to replace the prophesied Kingdom truth, as the "το μυστηριον." This Greek phrase transliterated into English forms the phrase "the mystery." This same Greek phrase translated into English means "the secret." It is unfortunate that the old English versions have transliterated rather than translating this word or phrase and that others have followed. It appears to me that in view of this the preferred approach today is to

expand the meaning of the word mystery to include what has been kept secret. The mystery revealed to the Apostle Paul was THE SECRET, a secret bodyof truth exclusively disclosed to him (cf. 1 Cor. 2:7; Eph. 3:3, 8-9; Col. 4:2-3).

In our judgment the Apostle Paul wrote fourteen of the New Testament epistles. These epistles fall into two groups. Those which were written *before the temporary laying aside of Israel* (Acts 28:28), approximately 60 A.D., *and those written after* the Israelites at Rome had confirmed their rejection of Jesus of Nazareth as the Messiah.

According to our observation THE GOSPEL OF THE GRACE OF GOD *contains two aspects: truth which relates to safvation and justification and truth which relates to the Body of Christ, the Church.*

During the time the Apostle Paul wrote the first group of epistles, which we will list *in the order written,* he was also *confirming the fact that Jesus of Nazareth is the Messiah to Israel* which means that the sign gifts still appear in some of these epistles (1 Cor.1:22). These epistles are: First Thessalonians, Second Thessalonians, Galatians, First Corinthians, Second Corinthians and Romans.

The second group of Epistles were written *after Israel had been both laid aside* and *Paul had received the full revelation of the mystery* and the full disclosure of the secret. There is no record of sign gifts being currently performed in these epistles, which are the ultimate standard for believers today. These epistles, in the order in which they were written are: Ephesians, Colossians, Philemon, Philippians, Titus, First Timothy, Second Timothy and Hebrews (may have been early).

SUMMARY

According to our observation, THE GOSPEL OF THE GRACE OF GOD contains two aspects: *truth which relates to salvation* and justification and *truth which relates to the Body of Christ,* the Church. These two aspects of truth are found in both groups of epistles; however, the salvation aspect is primarily found in the first group and the Body of Christ and Church aspect is most fully revealed in the second group.

Through evaluating the first group of epistles in the light of the second group, we are able to discern between *what is Jewish in nature* and what is for the Body of Christ. Through comparing the epistles in both groups our insight into what the Holy Spirit is saying through Paul is often increased. Through *using all that the Holy Spirit has written through the Apostle Paul as a standard for Church Truth,* we can determine what is and what is not applicable to members of the Body of Christ.

What we teach for believers to live by, from any portion of the *Bible, must conform to and be in alignment with what God the Holy Spirit has said in the Pauline Epistles!* May we bathe our minds in these epistles that Jesus Christ might have *first place* in our lives!

HOW GOD REVEALS
NEW DISPENSATIONAL TRUTH

The PURPOSE of this booklet is to point out the METHOD God has consistently used in revealing the truth for each dispensation.

DEFINITION

The Greek word translated DISPENSATION (οικονομια) is used nine times in the New Testament. It is used three times by Luke and six times in the Pauline Epistles. It is used two times in the Septuagint translation of Isaiah (22:19, 21), and several times in the Greek Papyri and other Greek literature. It is also used in Classical Greek.

We mention the widespread use of this word to help offset the influence of those who impugn a dispensational approach to the Bible. In the final analysis, a literal approach to the Bible forces us to recognize that we have no choice - we must acknowledge that it contains *several different dispensations* for different people living under different circumstances.

The basic meaning of this compound Greek word translated DISPENSATION (οικονομια) is the *management of a household.* In actual usage this could include the *plan, scheme* and *arrangement* involved in the management of an extended household, governmental affairs, and of economic matters. As used in Paul's Epistles, this word refers particularly to God's *management, arrangement, plan* and *administration* for this present dispensation of Grace.

DIFFERENT DISPENSATIONS

A general view of this subject indicates that God has given new truth to sixdifferent groups of people. In each case He revealed specific truth to ONE MAN, who in turn taught it to others. It is very important that we distinguish between the ONE MAN to whom God revealed the truth for a given dispensation, and those who were responsible for its dissemination among the people.

The basic meaning of this compound Greek word translated DISPENSATION is the management of a household. In actual usage this could include the plan, scheme and arrangement involved in the management of an extended household, governmental affairs, and of economic matters.

First, God revealed to ADAM the arrangement according to which he and his family were to live. Second, in view of the wickedness on the earth, God instructed NOAH to build an ark. Third, God ordered ABRAHAM to move from his homeland to Canaan, which lie promised to him and his descendants. Fourth, God instructed MOSES to lead the Israelites out of Egypt to the Promised Land, and to give them

the Law. Fifth, God sent His Son, THE GOD-MAN, to present the truth of the Kingdom to Israel and to die for sin. Sixth, after the Kingdom was rejected by Israel's leaders, God revealed unto the APOSTLE PAUL new truth, MYSTERY TRUTH, God's plan for the Church.

GOD ALWAYS REVEALED NEW TRUTH TO ONE MAN

After having observed that there are many wild statements floating around regarding what the Bible teaches, which lack solid Biblical support, I am convinced that what we affirm must be confirmed by the Word of God. The reason we are citing the following evidence is that you yourself, while reading it, may also acknowledge that God consistently reveals new dispensational truth to and through ONE MAN.

Furthermore, we are convinced that God always does what He does in the most efficient way possible. He reveals His Word to ONE MAN who in turn teaches it to others who disseminate it to all. God does not do what men can do via the Holy Spirit.

THE FIRST DISPENSATION WAS REVEALED TO ADAM

According to Genesis 2:16-17, God commanded Adam not to eat of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, and that the consequence of eating it would be death. This was the dispensational *arrangement* God made with Adam.

According to Genesis 2:24, God revealed to Adam that a man is to separate from his parents and be one flesh with his wife. This transdispensational, indissoluble, marital *plan* was revealed to Adam to pass on to his descendants.

According to Genesis 3:17-19, God revealed to Adam that his disobedience had brought a curse upon the ground, thorns and thistles, as a result of which he would have to sweatily work for his food. This transdispensational *arrangement* will exist until the removal of curse conditions (cf. vv. 23-24; Rom. 8:20-21).

In conclusion, we logically assume that what is recorded in the Book of Genesis is only a small part of all that God revealed to Adam. Obviously, God revealed to him the *kind* of an offering that was acceptable, that he was *not to kill,* etc., and he had passed this on to Cain and Abel, for they were *aware* of what was right and wrong (cf. Gen. 4:3-7).

THE SECOND DISPENSATION WAS REVEALED TO NOAH

Noah was the son of Lamech who was the son of Methuselah. He lived during a time when men were exceedingly wicked, when their imagination and thoughts were continually evil. In the midst of all this wickedness, Genesis 6:8 says, "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the Lord." In Genesis 6:9-10, we are told that he was a righteous man, that he walked with God, and that he had three sons, Shem, Ham and Japheth.

The method God used in revealing the Law was to communicate it to Moses who in turn communicated to the Israelites (cf. Exodus 24:3,12; 25:1-2).

According to Genesis 6:13, God told Noah that because of the wickedness and violence on the earth, that He was going to destroy the people with the earth. According to Genesis 6:14-16, God revealed to Noah the dimensions and details regarding the ark. In verses 18-21, God tells Noah to take his wife and his sons and their wives into the ark; also, he was to take a male and female of every living thing. According to Genesis 6:22, Noah built the ark and loaded it according to God's instructions.

After the Flood had come and subsided, God told Noah and his sons to repopulate the earth (Gen. 9:1). This may be interpreted that God blessed Noah and his sons as a SINGLE ENTITY, the progeny of ONE MAN, who as ONE FAMILY were preserved for *the rapid replenishing of the earth.* It may also mean that God spoke to Noah and via him to his sons, the normal way new dispensational truth is revealed.

According to Genesis 9:6, it was revealed to Noah, that since God created man in His own image, therefore, murderers shall be put to death by man (human government). This is a transdispensational *arrangement* which has not been annulled or replaced. This penalty obviously applies to the premeditated, purposeful and willful killing of human beings, which includes unborn children.

In conclusion, prior to the Flood God revealed his purpose and will *exclusively to Noah.* After the Flood God revealed His truth for the new earth *to Noah and through him* to his sons, or *to Noah* as the HEAD OF A FAMILY.

THE THIRD DISPENSATION

WAS REVEALED TO ABRAHAM

Abraham was born in Ur of the Chaldees. He moved with Terah, his father, to Haran. After his father's death, God told him to leave Haran and his relatives, to go to Canaan, and that He *would make him a great nation* through which all the families of the earth would be blessed (Gen. 12:1-3).

Abraham's first stop in Canaan was Shechem, where the Lord *promised the land to his descendants,* and where he built an altar unto the Lord (Gen. 12:6-7). His second stop was east of Bethel, where he also built an altar and called upon the name of the Lord (Gen. 12:8). After a short sojourn south into Egypt, Abraham returned to Bethel, Lot chose the Plain of the Jordan, and *God reaffirms His promise of the land and countless descendants* to Abraham (Gen. 13:14-17).

Again Abraham went south to the Hebron area. He built an altar there unto the Lord. When he was discouraged about not having a son, God told him to look at the innumerable stars, that his descendants would be the same. As a result of this truth revealed to him,we are told *that Abraham believed the Lord, and it was counted to him for righteousness* (Gen. 15:4-7, 18).

Furthermore, in Genesis 17:1-8, God again confirmed to Abraham that He would *establish His covenant with him and his descendants for an everlasting covenant.* Also, He promised to Abraham and his descendants all the land of Canaan *for an everlasting possession.* We see the first step toward the fulfillment of the foregoing promises in the conception and birth of Isaac (Gen. 21:1-2).

It is important to observe that Jesus Christ was God sole Revealer and Possessor of Messianic Kingdom truth in the New Testament.

In conclusion, according to the foregoing citations of what God had to say to Abraham and his descendants, *He revealed directly to Abraham.* The main truths God revealed to hiın pertained to the promise of a LAND, a SON and RIGHTEOUSNESS. The Promised Land extended from the river of Egypt (Nile) to the Euphrates river, which awaits complete fulfillment. God reaffirmed this promise to Abraham and through him confirmed it to his descendants. The promise regarding a son, an heir, and the innumerable descendants was fulfilled in God's due time, making the conception and birth of Isaac a miracle in itself. The fact of *righteousness by faith was first revealed to Abraham* and via him to his descendants, and secondarily, via the Spirit, to all believers (Gal. 3:29).

THE FOURTH DISPENSATION

WAS REVEALED TO MOSES

According to Exodus 3:1-10, *Godrevealed His will for His people, the Israelites, to Moses,* whom He chose to lead them out of Egypt to the Promised Land.

According to Exodus 20:1-17, *God revealed the Ten Commandments to Moses* to give to Israel. This involved a new dispensational arrangement between God and His people. In contrast to how He had carried them out of Egypt on eagle's wings, they now enter into a covenant arrangement in which their relationship with God will depend upon *what they do,* i.e., their obeying God's commandments (19:4-5).

According to Exodus 23:29-30, God reveals to Moses the *slow plan* He will use in driving out the inhabitants of Canaan. He will not force them out in one year, lest the land become desolate, and the wild beasts multiply and become predators. The method God used in revealing the Law was *to communicate it to Moses* who inturn communicated to the Israelites (cf. Exodus 24:3, 12; 25:1-2).

In conclusion, God revealed the Law unto ONE MAN, Moses, who in turn taught it unto the leaders of the people, who made it known unto the people (cf. Exodus 19:3, 7-8).

All the evidence that is recorded indicates that God revealed the basictruth for the first dispensation to and through ADAM. Likewise, the basic truth for the second dispensation was revealed to and through NOAH, his three sons being closely related as co-progenitors of a new race. Furthermore, the truth for the third dispensationwas revealed to ABRAHAM and confirmed to his descendants. Finally,

the truth for the fourth dispensation was revealed to MOSES and passed on to the elders and people. The combined witness of the Old Testament is that God *has always revealed new truth for each dispensation to and through ONE MAN*, not many.

THE FIFTH DISPENSATION

WAS REVEALED BY THE GOD-MAN

Having observed that the specific truth for each dispensation *was revealed to ONE MAN in the Old Testament,* now let us consider if this same method also applies to the New Testament.

The fact that a special revelation of truth, a new dispensation, was revealed unto the Apostle Paul is indisputable (cf.1 Cor. 9:17; Eph. 3:7-9; Col.1:25).

As we approach the New Testament, we are introduced to the Synoptic Gospels: Matthew, Mark and Luke. In these, *the God-man, Jesus Christ,* PRESENTS the truth regarding the Messianic Kingdom. This includes information pertaining to its nature, stringent laws, sovereign government and the requirements for entering it, namely, repentance and water baptism.

It is important to observe *that Jesus Christ was God's sole Revealer and Possessor of* Messianic Kingdom truth in the New Testament. He was both the source and the Discloser of the truth pertaining to this Kingdom. *He extended it via the Holy Spirit to the Twelve disciples* to offer it to Israel. The Twelve Disciples were not the ones to whom this Kingdom truth was revealed, but *it was given to them to dispense* in conjunction with their offer of the kingdoın to Israel (cf. Acts 3:18-26).

Thus we observe, even in the case of Jesus Christ, the ONE OF GOD, *He Himself possessed the truth of the Kingdom,* and via the Holy Spirit *He shared it with the Twelve Disciples to disseminate to Israel.*

THE SIXTH DISPENSATION

WAS REVEALED TO THE APOSTLE PAUL

In Ephesians 3:2-3, The Apostle Paul says, "if you have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God that was given to me for you, that according to revelation the mystery was made known to me as I previously wrote briefly." The fact that a special revelation of truth, a new dispensation, was revealed unto the Apostle Paul is indisputable (cf. 1 Cor. 9:17; Eph. 3:7-9; Col. 1:25).

Inseparable from the new dispensation revealed unto the Apostle Paul is the truth of the Mystery. This refers to truth which was in the form of a secret before it was revealed to Paul. The heart of this revealed secret is the body of Christ, the Church, and all that it involves. The Apostle Paul makes it very clear that this mystery or secret *was revealed unto Him;* in fact, he says that *his gospel is in accordance with the Mystery* (Rom. 16:25; cf. 1 Cor. 2:6-10; Eph. 1:9; 6:19-20; Col. 1:25-27; 4:3-4).

The Apostle Paul is the *only one who claims and declares* that the DISPENSATION (οικονομια) of the grace of God was revealed to him. Also, he is the only one who claims and affirms that the MYSTERY (μυστηριον) was revealed or given unto him. No other New Testament writer even mentions the words dispensation or mystery let alone claiming that the same were revealed unto him. Furthermore, no other writer uses any terminology which would suggest that the same thing was directly revealed unto him apart from having received it from Paul.

Since traditional Christianity has failed to recognize the distinct ministry revealed unto the Apostle Paul, many prefer to *follow tradition* rather than taking the literal-intended meaning of the Word of God. For example, some have failed to *adequately consider the context* surrounding Ephesians 3:5 and have concluded that apart from Paul, the Spirit has also revcaled the mystery to the apostles and prophets.

A careful study of these epistles indicates that the mystery was excelusively given to Paul, and via the Spirit, given to others to disseminate or spread abroad.

In as much as many are trying to use Ephesians 3:5 to undercut the fact that the Mystery was given only to the Apostle Paul, it is very important that we consider the exact meaning of this verse in the light of the context which precedes and follows it. Also, we need to consider it in the light of what the Apostle Paul says in all his epistles - that *the Mystery was given to him and* not to others. A careful study of these epistles indicates that the mystery was *exclusively given to Paul,* and via the Spirit, given to others to disseminate or spread abroad.

The following is our literal translation of Ephesians 3:5; "which in other generations was not made known to the sons of men, as it now has been revealed to his holy apostles and prophets by the Spirit."

Now let me give you a literal translation of what precedes this verse with applicable comments. Beginning with this chapter, and verse 1, we read, "For this cause I, Paul, the prisoner of Christ Jesus on behalf of you Gentiles." Note the introductory facts, "I, Paul" emphasizes the fact that he is the writer. He was writing from prison in Rome. He was in prison "on behalf of you Gentiles" (υπερ υμων των εθνων). Note, he is directing what he is saying *to Gentiles.* In fact, in the forepart of this chapter he is explaining where he received authority to say to the Gentiles in chapter 2:19, "you are fellow-citizens with the saints and family of God."

Having observed that Paul, as the Apostle of the Gentiles, is addressing what he is saying in the first 13 verses in this chapter primarily to Gentiles, observe what he says in verse 2: "if you have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God that was given to me for you." Here he affirms that the dispensation of the grace of God had specifically been given unto him for them, i.e., *to be passed unto them by the Spirit* through the apostles and prophets associated with him.

As we proceed in this context it is obvious that the dispensation of the grace of God given to the Apostle Paul *encompassed the Mystery;* it involved Mystery truth.

Our literal translation ofverse 3 is as follows: "that according to revelation the mystery was made known to me as I previously wrote briefly." In this verse the Apostle makes it crystal clear that *the Mystery had been made known to him* according to "revelation" (αποκαλυψιν), i.e., *the secret truth which had been hidden was disclosed unto him.*

Referring to what he had previously written to them about the Mystery, Paul says in verse 4, "which considering, you are able while reading to perceive my understanding in the mystery of Christ." This verse indicates that while the Gentiles read the brief description of the Mystery which Paul had sent to them, they will be able to comprehend *his understanding in the Mystery, the secret truth,* which belongs to Christ. The implication is that only Paul had an understanding of the Mystery, which he had shared with them via a letter, and that they are now able to perceive his knowledge of this secret.

For convenience I will restate verse 5 again, instead of asking you to refer back to it. With reference to the Mystery, Paul says, "which in other generations was not made known to the sons of men, as it now has been revealed to his holy apostles and prophets by the Spirit." Let us observe *two contrasting groups* in this verse. First, it had never previously been made known to the sons of men" (υιοις), *the human race in past time.* Second, but now it has been "revealed to his holy apostles and prophets by the Spirit.

Indeed, the Mystery was given and made known to the Apostle Paul that the Spirit, using the apostles and prophets associated with Paul, might spread it abroad according to the Lord's will.

In keeping with the language used in this context the thought is that *the Mystery was made known to the Apostle Paul* and in turn *was revealed by the Spirit to the apostles and prophets associated with Paul,* to disseminate and *spread abroad the fact* that the Gentiles are "fellow-heirs and fellow-body members and fellow-partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus through the gospel."

The apostles and prophets mentioned in Ephesians 3:5 are *those who were associated with the early ministry of the Apostle Paul* (cf. I Cor.12:28; 14:29, 32, 37; Rom.16:7; Eph.4:11; et al). For anyone to attempt to identify these apostles with the Twelve Kingdom Apostles is to stretch the imagination beyond all reason. We have pointed out that this verse is in the midst of a tightly knit Gentile context, in which the Apostle of the Gentiles, Paul, affirms that Mystery Truth gives the Gentiles *the right to be members of the Body of Christ.* Again, I emphasize, it is utterly unthinkable for anyone to try to inject the Twelve Jewish Apostles into this Gentile context (cf. Gal. 2:7-9).

Furthermore, *three times* this context emphasizes that the dispensation of the grace of God and the truth of the Mystery were *GIVEN unto the Apostle Paul, one time* that the Mystery *was made known to him,* and *one time* that it was *through him* (Eph. 3:2, 3, 7, 8, 9, 10). Indeed, *the Mystery was given and made known to the*

Apostle Paul that the Spirit, *using the apostles and prophets associated with Paul, might spread it abroad* according to the Lord's will.

SUMMARIZING

Even as the Lord revealed new dispensational truth to one man in the Old Testament, for example, to Adam, Noah, Abraham and Moses, in the New Testament, He revealed new dispensational thruth to and through Jesus Christ, and finally, to the *Apostle Paul.* He is the APOSTLE OF THE CHURCH, THE BODY OF CHRIST, the ONE *to whom* and *through whom the Gospel of the Grace of God and the Mystery has been revealed!*